

GRAVELKING PRO

The Founder's Funding & Growth Playbook

A plain-language 15-page plan for turning the JAX songwriting companion, IP-rights workflow, MLK v3 mastering, and horizontal stem nesting into a fundable, revenue-producing company.

Prepared for the founder • September 2026

The goal is not to look investable. The goal is to become obviously useful, measurably growing, and easy to fund.

1. The honest evaluation

Where GravelKing Pro stands today

Area	Evaluation	What would raise the score
Product differentiation	Strong	Demonstrate before/after audio and a repeatable stem-nesting method
Technical moat	Promising	Document the method, tests, and protected implementation; show why copying is hard
Customer proof	Unknown / needs evidence	10–20 paying or design-partner customers with measurable outcomes
Business model	Present but complex	One clear primary customer and one simple paid offer
Fundability today	Pre-seed / angel possible	Traction packet, clean numbers, focused ask, and warm introductions
Debt readiness	Early	Bankable records, revenue, repayment source, business separation, lender package

Bottom line: GravelKing Pro is more interesting than a generic AI music generator, but it is not yet automatically investable. The investable story is the workflow and evidence: a creator can develop an idea in JAX, establish authorship/provenance, process it through a distinct mastering method, and leave with a usable, rights-aware artifact.

That is a real wedge. It combines creation, finishing, and proof of ownership instead of selling one more “make a song” button.

Your current weakness is not the invention. It is proof: how many people use it, how often they return, what they pay, how much it costs to serve them, and whether the result is better than familiar tools.

Current scorecard:

Do not pitch four businesses at once. Pitch one beachhead: **independent artists and small creator teams who need a guided path from idea to release-ready, rights-aware audio.** The other features become reasons to stay.

2. Your moat, in plain English

What makes the company more than an app

Moat means “why a capable competitor cannot copy the whole advantage next week.” A patent is not the only moat. For GravelKing Pro, the strongest moat is a stack of smaller advantages that reinforce each other:

- Workflow moat: JAX → authorship/provenance → mastering → export is one continuous path, not disconnected tools.
- Method moat: MLK v3 mastering plus horizontal stem nesting gives you a specific technical point of view. Do not describe it vaguely; show inputs, outputs, constraints, and measurable results.
- Evidence moat: every project can accumulate provenance, edits, certificates, and repeat-use history. Over time that becomes a dataset and trust layer.
- Brand moat: GravelKing Pro can own “finished, rights-aware creator audio,” not merely “AI music.”
- Distribution moat: partnerships with vocal coaches, producer communities, indie labels, music schools, and creator agencies can create lower-cost access to users.

Important: do not claim legal ownership, copyright clearance, or patent protection beyond what your actual contracts, registrations, and product controls support. Investors punish overclaiming faster than they punish an early stage.

Your one-sentence moat statement:

“GravelKing Pro gives independent creators a guided, evidence-backed path from a song idea to release-ready sound, combining JAX songwriting, provenance, and MLK v3 mastering in one workflow.”

3. Turn the product into a fundable wedge

What to lead with and what to hide for now

Lead with	Why it matters
"Bring an idea, leave with a finished, documented track."	Simple outcome
Before/after mastering demo	Makes the method tangible
JAX creative companion	Shows the starting point and user habit
Provenance/certificate flow	Creates trust and a paid upgrade
Horizontal stem nesting	Specific technical differentiation; demonstrate, do not lecture
Library, profile, pinning, cover changes	Shows the product is becoming a real home for work

Lead with the moment a customer feels the value. Do not lead with architecture. A funder should understand the transformation in 20 seconds.

For the next 90 days, make the product promise narrower:

- Target: independent artists who release or publish content regularly.
- Activation: first usable song idea or upload completed.
- Aha moment: hear the mastered result and see the provenance record.
- Paid event: mastering, certificate, export, or recurring studio access.
- Retention event: user returns to revise, master another track, or download/share.

The investor does not need every feature. The investor needs a believable loop: **creator arrives → gets value → pays or returns → tells another creator.**

4. The numbers investors will ask for

Build this dashboard before asking for a serious check

Metric	Definition	Target direction
Visitors → signup	Unique visitors who create an account	Up
Signup → first JAX action	New users who send a meaningful prompt	Up
First action → generated/finished work	Users who complete a usable artifact	Up
Activation rate	New users reaching the aha moment within 7 days	Up
Week-4 retention	Activated users returning in week 4	Up
Paid conversion	Users paying for a plan, credit, mastering, or certificate	Up
Revenue per active user	Revenue divided by monthly active users	Up
Gross margin	Revenue minus direct generation/storage/payment costs	Up
Runway	Cash available divided by monthly burn	At least 6–12 months

Analytics are not decoration. They are your proof. Track a small number of events consistently and report weekly.

Minimum investor evidence packet: 90 days of weekly users, activation, paid conversions, revenue, refunds, costs, and notable customer quotes. If the numbers are small, say so. Honest small numbers beat inflated vague numbers.

Create one “North Star” metric: **completed creator projects per month**. A project counts only when the user creates or imports work and reaches a meaningful finish event (mastered, exported, certified, or shared).

5. Make the business easy to understand

Pricing, revenue, and the first repeatable offer

Offer	Customer promise	Role
Free	Try JAX and experience the workflow	Acquisition
Pro	Regular creator workflow with mastering allowance	Recurring revenue
King / Studio	Higher limits and advanced controls	Expansion
Credits	Pay for occasional exports, certificates, or intensive actions	Monetization of variable cost
Creator services / pilots	Guided onboarding for teams, schools, or labels	Early cash + learning

A complicated catalog makes investors wonder whether customers understand what they are buying. Keep the public offer simple even if the backend is sophisticated.

Pick one primary paid conversion for the pitch. Example: “Our first paid wedge is a creator subscription; credits monetize bursty usage without giving away unlimited expensive processing.”

Do not sell investors on a future marketplace yet. First prove the direct product. A marketplace, label network, or licensing layer can be a later expansion once supply and demand are real.

Cash now options: founding-member annual plans, paid onboarding sessions, producer/artist pilot packages, school or studio bundles, and white-glove mastering credits. These are not embarrassing. They are customer-funded validation.

6. Become angel-ready in 30 days

The preparation checklist

Angels invest in people who can explain the opportunity, prove learning speed, and use money to reach a specific next milestone. “We need money to grow” is not a milestone.

- Legal: confirm entity, ownership, tax ID, operating agreement/bylaws, founder equity, IP assignment, contractor agreements, and cap table.
- Finance: separate bank account, bookkeeping, monthly profit-and-loss, cash balance, burn, revenue by product, and a 12-month forecast.
- IP: list what is owned by the company, what is licensed, what is open-source, and what is a trade secret. Keep dated technical records.
- Customer proof: 10 interviews, 5 active testers, 3 strong testimonials, and ideally 3 paying customers or signed pilots.
- Security/trust: privacy policy, terms, data deletion, audio privacy rules, backup process, and clear claims around certificates.
- Fundraising materials: 10–12 slide pitch, one-page summary, data room, demo link, and a specific use-of-funds plan.
- Ask: choose a round size and a milestone. Example: “We are raising \$250,000 to reach 500 activated creators, 100 paid accounts, and 65% gross margin over 12 months.”

If you cannot answer where every dollar goes, you are not ready to ask for money. You are ready to ask for customer feedback and paid pilots first.

7. Where to look for angels and programs

Start with fit, not fame

Route	Why it fits	How to approach
Gust	Startup profile and applications to angel groups and accelerators	Build a complete company profile; apply to relevant groups
Band of Angels	Technology-focused angel group with a public “Apply to Present” path	Submit through the official application; emphasize software and traction
Techstars	Accelerator network; fit depends on current program and geography	Check current programs and apply only where creator/AI/software fit is real
SBA / SBDC / SCORE	Not equity investors, but useful for readiness, counseling, and lender preparation	Book a counselor before taking expensive debt
CDFIs and local lenders	Often more mission-oriented and relationship-based than banks	Find local CDFI; bring records, tax ID, forecast, and repayment plan
Gust / Angel groups / founder referrals	Distribution channels to multiple investors	Ask customers, attorneys, accountants, and operators for warm intros

Use public application routes and warm introductions. Do not guess private email addresses. The target list below is a starting map, not an endorsement or guarantee.

Useful public sources: Gust (gust.com), Band of Angels (bandangels.com/overview), SBA Lender Match (sba.gov), SBA Microloans (sba.gov/microloans), and the CDFI Fund locator (cdfifund.gov). Verify terms and eligibility directly because programs change.

8. Who to contact and what to say

Ready-to-send messages

Warm introduction request:

“Hi [Name] — I’m building GravelKing Pro, a creator-audio platform that combines JAX songwriting, provenance, and MLK v3 mastering into one workflow. I’m looking for 3–5 investors or operators who understand creator software, music technology, or AI infrastructure. Would you be comfortable introducing me to one person who might be a fit? I can send a one-page summary and a 90-second demo.”

Investor cold email:

Subject: GravelKing Pro — rights-aware creator audio workflow

“Hi [Name], I’m [Founder], founder of GravelKing Pro. We help independent creators move from idea to release-ready audio with a songwriting companion, provenance tools, and a distinct mastering workflow. We are raising [\$X] to reach [specific milestone] over [time]. Our wedge is [specific customer], and our proof so far is [truthful metric]. If this fits your interest in creator software/music/AI, may I send a one-page summary and demo?”

Follow-up after 5–7 business days:

“Just closing the loop on GravelKing Pro. The short version: [customer] uses us to [outcome], and we are measuring [metric]. If it is not a fit, a referral to one creator-tech investor or operator would still help.”

Never send a giant life story in the first message. Ask for a conversation, not a check.

9. Your 10-slide pitch

The story investors should hear

Slide	Say this
1. Title	GravelKing Pro: from song idea to finished, documented audio
2. Problem	Creators use disconnected tools and lack a trusted path from creation to finished release
3. Customer	Independent artists and small creator teams who need speed, quality, and evidence
4. Product	JAX + provenance + MLK v3 mastering + library/export workflow
5. Why now	Creator tools are expanding; trust, attribution, and quality remain unresolved
6. Differentiation	Workflow, mastering method, evidence layer, and distribution partnerships
7. Traction	Show real users, activation, paid conversion, retention, revenue, and testimonials
8. Business model	Subscription first; credits and certificates monetize variable/value-heavy actions
9. Go-to-market	Communities, producers, schools, vocal coaches, creator agencies, referrals
10. Ask	Amount, instrument, runway, milestones, and what the investor unlocks

The pitch is not “AI will change music.” The pitch is “Here is the customer, here is the painful workflow, here is the measurable outcome, here is why we can win, and here is exactly what this round buys.”

10. How to pursue a loan with little credit history

Debt is repayment, not belief

A tax ID is helpful but does not create credit by itself. A lender mainly asks: who repays, from what cash flow, with what collateral or guarantee, and what happens if revenue is late?

- Start with SBA-backed counseling, not a high-cost online lender. SBA Lender Match can help identify participating lenders; SBDC and SCORE can help prepare the package.
- Investigate SBA Microloans for smaller needs through approved intermediaries. Terms, eligibility, collateral, and guarantees vary.
- Check local CDFIs. They may be more willing to evaluate a thin-file business with a strong plan and community impact.
- Open/maintain business banking, keep books clean, pay vendors on time, and avoid mixing personal and business spending.
- Ask for the smallest amount that achieves a revenue milestone. A \$10,000–\$25,000 equipment/working-capital request tied to signed pilots is easier to defend than a vague \$150,000 request.
- Avoid merchant cash advances and daily/weekly repayment products unless the effective cost and downside are fully understood.

Lender package: formation documents, tax ID confirmation, owner ID, bank statements, P&L, balance sheet, tax returns if available, accounts receivable, contracts/pilots, forecast, debt schedule, use of funds, and repayment plan.

A lender will not value a “moat” the same way an angel does. Translate the moat into cash flow: “This workflow helps us sell X subscriptions / Y pilot packages at Z gross margin.”

11. How to create income before investment

Customer-funded progress

Offer	Buyer	Example deliverable
Founding Creator Pass	Independent artist	Guided setup, JAX sessions, mastering credits, provenance record
Producer / Studio Pilot	Producer or small studio	10–25 seats, onboarding, usage report, feedback session
School / Community Cohort	Music program, nonprofit, creator community	Workshop + limited cohort access + outcome report
Rights-aware release package	Artist/manager	Track workflow, certificate support, export, documentation
Partner referral	Coach, vocal booth, producer, agency	Commission or bundled access

The fastest path is usually not “find an investor.” It is “sell a narrow result to a small number of people, then use that proof to raise.”

Use a simple pilot contract: scope, number of users, duration, price, what data is collected, support boundaries, and what success means. Do not promise legal copyright outcomes you cannot guarantee.

Weekly income rule: every week, ask for money from a real customer, not only feedback. Even one paid pilot changes the conversation.

12. The 90-day acceleration plan

What to do first, second, and third

Days	Priority	Deliverable
1–14	Narrow the wedge	One ideal customer profile, one paid offer, one demo, one-page summary
15–30	Sell pilots	20 targeted conversations; 5 demos; 2 paid or signed pilots
31–45	Instrument proof	Activation, retention, paid conversion, gross margin, customer quotes
46–60	Make the data room	Cap table, IP list, agreements, financials, product/security docs
61–75	Build the investor list	40 fit-based targets; 10 warm intro requests; 10 official applications
76–90	Run the raise	12–20 first meetings; weekly updates; ask for referrals and next steps

Founder schedule: 40% selling and customer calls, 25% product reliability, 15% evidence/analytics, 10% fundraising, 10% administration. If you spend 90% of the next quarter coding, you will know less about demand than you know today.

Fast does not mean frantic. Fast means reducing uncertainty in the right order: customer → paid result → repeat use → margin → scalable acquisition.

13. Your data room and credibility file

Make diligence easy

Create a private folder with these sections. Name files clearly and date important versions.

- 01 Company: formation, tax ID, ownership, cap table, founder bios.
- 02 Product: demo link, architecture overview, roadmap, uptime/reliability notes, screenshots.
- 03 IP: invention/method summary, code ownership, contractor assignments, licenses, trademarks, registrations, trade-secret controls.
- 04 Market: customer profile, competitor grid, interview notes, pricing tests, market sources.
- 05 Traction: analytics export, cohort table, revenue, subscriptions, credits, churn, testimonials, case studies.
- 06 Finance: P&L, balance sheet, bank statements, burn, forecast, use of funds, assumptions.
- 07 Legal/trust: terms, privacy, data deletion, audio privacy, customer agreements, certificate language.
- 08 Fundraise: pitch, one-pager, investor list, outreach log, draft term sheet questions.

Be especially careful with rights language. “Provenance record” and “certificate” are product features; they are not automatically a legal copyright registration or a promise that a government, platform, or court will accept every claim.

The easiest company to fund is the company that answers questions before the investor asks them.

14. The founder's operating promise

How you get there faster

You do not need a 99% guarantee. You need a repeatable process that makes rejection useful and progress visible.

Every week: talk to 5 target customers, ask 2 for payment, ship 1 reliability improvement, review the funnel, and request 2 introductions.

Every month: publish an internal scorecard: active creators, completed projects, paid accounts, revenue, gross margin, retention, cash, and runway.

Every investor conversation: leave with one of three outcomes—next meeting, a specific introduction, or a clear no with a reason. “Keep me posted” is not a pipeline stage.

Your closing ask:

“I am not asking you to believe in a slogan. I am asking you to look at the workflow, the customer evidence, and the milestone this capital buys. If you are not the right investor, who is one person I should meet?”

Sources checked for this playbook: Gust — <https://gust.com/> ; Band of Angels — <https://www.bandangels.com/overview> ; U.S. Small Business Administration Lender Match — <https://www.sba.gov/lender-match> ; SBA Microloans — <https://www.sba.gov/funding-programs/loans/microloans> ; CDFI Fund — <https://www.cdfifund.gov/> ; MIDiA Research creator tools overview — <https://www.midiaresearch.com/reports/midia-research-20252031-music-creator-tools-forecasts-ai-comes-to-town>

This is strategic education, not legal, tax, securities, or lending advice. Before accepting investment, issuing equity, signing a note, or making rights claims, use a qualified attorney/accountant who understands startups and music technology.

Start with the next paid pilot. Then make the evidence undeniable.